then, the hijacking incident left a deep imprint on India's vision of the Taliban.[136] The incident lay bare the difference between India and the Taliban's world-view. Already wary of the Taliban, India went further into an embrace with the fractured United Front.[137]

New Delhi faced two different policy dilemmas during the hijack. Firstly, having concluded that the hijacking was being clandestinely supported by Pakistan and had roots in the Kashmir problem, the question was whether to negotiate with the hijackers or not. According to L. K. Advani, senior BJP leader and then home minister, negotiating with the hijackers would make India look 'soft' on the issue of terrorism and would amount to 'appeasement of terrorists'.[138] He wanted India to exercise proactive policies similar to those of China and Israel, which was storming the plane militarily, regardless of the human and economic costs involved.[139] Other leaders, including Vajpayee, Jaswant Singh, and Brajesh Mishra (who was India's representative to the UN in 1980 when the Soviet intervention occurred), viewed the crisis from a humanitarian and political perspective.[140] More killings due to government inaction, or hyper-action, would mean political suicide for the BJP-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA) government. The policy direction, thus, was: '(a) the earliest termination of the hijacking; (b) the safe return of the passengers, crew and aircraft; and (c) safeguarding national security.'[141] Negotiations with the hijackers became imperative to achieve these objectives. Consequently, talking to the Taliban became essential. After years of no contact, when circumstances forced India to engage with the Taliban. Secondly, there was the long-term strategic dilemma of how to deal with the Taliban, particularly because the UF was close to being wiped out militarily by then, and more disturbingly, had no value for India during the hijacking crisis itself.

Though the eight-day ordeal left India convinced of the Pakistan-Taliban nexus, it also left New Delhi shocked by its own strategic failure to develop ties with all Afghan groups. As MoS for external affairs Ajit Panja told the parliament three months after the incident, the termination of the hijacking in the manner it was achieved was the 'best possible solution in a basket of worse alternatives'.[142] For then foreign secretary Mansingh, India had realised at that point, that it 'had lost out in Afghanistan'.[143] Almost every interviewee, from the MEA to the